

Ansible vs SaltStack Beginner Guide and Cheatsheet

Configuration management tools help you automate server setup and maintain consistency across environments. Understanding the key differences between Ansible and SaltStack will help you choose the right tool for your DevOps journey.

What you'll learn:

- 1 Ansible Agentless Ping Test
- 2 Ansible Playbook Deployment
- 3 SaltStack Instant Ping Test
- 4 SaltStack State Enforcement

Aman Raj Singh

Cloud Operations Engineer @ iManage

[linkedin.com/in/mramanrajsingh](https://www.linkedin.com/in/mramanrajsingh)

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Ansible Agentless Ping Test

Ansible connects to target servers using standard SSH, meaning no extra software needs to run on remote nodes. You list your server IP addresses in an inventory file and execute modules directly. This agentless design makes initial setup fast and easy for beginners.

```
$ansible all -m ping -i inventory.ini
```

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Ansible Playbook Deployment

Playbooks are written in simple YAML syntax to define tasks like installing packages, starting services, or copying files. You run them against your inventory to automate server configuration reliably. If a task is already completed, Ansible skips it safely.

```
$ansible-playbook -i inventory.ini deploy-app.yml
```

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SaltStack Instant Ping Test

SaltStack uses a master-minion architecture where lightweight minion software stays connected to a central master server. This agent-based design enables high-speed communication across thousands of machines simultaneously. You can ping all connected minions instantly with a single command.

```
$salt '*' test.ping
```

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SaltStack State Enforcement

Salt State files define how your infrastructure should look at all times. When you apply a state, Salt checks each minion and brings non-compliant settings back into order. This event-driven approach ensures your servers remain correctly configured automatically.

```
$salt '*' state.apply webserver
```

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Key Takeaways

- + Start with Ansible if you need quick automation without managing agent software.
- + Use SaltStack when managing over 1,000 servers that demand real-time speed.
- + Keep inventory files organized and separate environment variables from code.
- + Test commands in local virtual machines before touching production systems.
- + Write clean YAML files using proper two-space indentation to avoid syntax errors.

Watch Out For

- ! Forgetting that Ansible requires working SSH permissions and SSH keys on target machines.
- ! Installing Salt Minions without accepting their security keys on the Salt Master server.
- ! Mixing tabs and spaces inside YAML configuration files.
- ! Overcomplicating simple server automation tasks with event reactors too early.

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